> The fact that it has taken sometime to collect any information on the matter that might in any sense be said to be representative of the opinion of any particular class is … in itself indicative that there is very little public opinion on the matter and what there is, is generally of lukewarm character … what little opinion now exists in one or two centres in this district … will soon die out from want of public interest in it.[75]

The collector could not have been more wrong.

The exuberant Swadeshi mood is captured in Subramania Bharati's exultation that the Swadeshi movement had taken root in the Tirunelveli district. He offered prayers for the success of the efforts of the Tuticorin traders.[76] Tuticorin was on the boil, and VOC and his shipping venture was raising the temperature. Madras was quickly beginning to shed its image of 'a benighted province' and 'a sleepy hollow'. The Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company became the flagship of the movement. And all eyes turned to Tuticorin.